

SF HACKS x GDG

AI Hackathon

Participant Handbook

October 2, 2026 | 9:00 AM – 7:00 PM

Student Life Events Center / Annex

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1. WELCOME

Welcome to the **SF Hacks x GDG AI Hackathon!**

We are thrilled to welcome you to an adventure in innovation, collaboration, and technology. This event is a place for students to come together and build something exciting. You do not need to be an expert to participate. **All skill levels are welcome.** The goal is to learn new skills, meet awesome people, build something you're excited about, and have fun!

Remember that hackathons are a lot like marathons. Some people participate to compete, but many participate to challenge themselves, learn something new, and meet other people. Whatever brings you to the hackathon, we encourage you to embrace the hacker spirit by collaborating with others, helping beginners, sharing knowledge, and having fun.

This handbook contains the important information, rules, schedules, and resources you will need to make the most of your hackathon experience.

Happy hacking!

SF Hacks x GDG Team

2. EVENT INFORMATION

Date & Time

Date: Friday, October 2, 2026

Time: 9:00 AM – 8:00 PM

Location:

Annex I

1 N State Dr, San Francisco, CA 94132

Venue Location Map



Parking:

Daily Parking

Daily Parking Fee is \$11.25 and the Annex is located just northwest of **Lots 19 and 20**, near the campus parking garage.



Lot 25, located just north of Winston Drive and east of Lake Merced Boulevard, is also near the Annex.

More parking information:

<https://activities.sfsu.edu/parking-directions-and-shipping-information>

Public Transportation:

Transportation reimbursements will not be provided, but we highly recommend using public transportation when possible.

From BART

Daly City BART Station → 57 Bus → 5-minute walk

- Get off at Winston Dr. & Lake Merced Blvd.

Daly City BART Station → 58 Bus → 5-minute walk

- Get off at Winston Dr. & Lake Merced Blvd.

Balboa Park BART Station → 29 Bus → 5-minute walk

- Get off at Winston Dr. & Lake Merced Blvd.

Muni Metro Light Rail

Embarcadero Muni Station → M Line → 15-minute walk

- Get off at San Francisco State University.

Contact Information

Discord:

<https://discord.com/invite/2KwpfmGcU>

Email:

sfhacksteam@gmail.com

3. BEFORE THE HACKATHON

A little preparation before the event will help you make the most of your hackathon experience.

Team Formation

Participants are welcome to register as a team before the event.

Tip: Teams with a mix of skills; such as coding, design, project management, hardware, and presentation often create well-rounded projects.

Also during the check in time you have time to meet with other participants who are looking for a team. Just talk to people, introduce yourself and let them know you are looking for a teammate.

When introducing yourself, consider sharing:

- Your skills
- Your experience level
- Technologies you're interested in
- What you're hoping to build
- What you're looking for in teammates

Preparation

Before the hackathon:

- Thoroughly read the hackathon rules.
- Review the submission requirements.
- Review the demo and judging process.
- Review the judging criteria.
- Brush up on technologies or tools you think may be useful during the hackathon.

You don't need to know exactly what you're going to build before arriving.

What to Bring

Please make sure you bring:

- Laptop
- Laptop charger
- Phone charger
- Adapters you may need
- Any additional hardware you plan to use
- A reusable water bottle to stay hydrated
- Any other personal items you may need during the day

Before arriving, make sure your computer is working properly and install any development tools or software you expect to use.

4. EVENT DAY SCHEDULE

Here is what your day will look like.

Time	Event	Details
9:00 AM – 10:00 AM	Check-In & Team Building	Get checked in, meet other participants, and find teammates.
10:00 AM – 11:00 AM	Opening Ceremony	Welcome, event overview, and important announcements.
11:00 AM	Hacking Begins!	Teams begin working on their projects.
12:00 PM – 1:00 PM	Workshop #1	Attend an optional workshop to learn new skills while continuing to work on your project.
1:00 PM – 2:00 PM	Lunch	Take a break and enjoy lunch.
2:00 PM – 4:30 PM	Hacking & Project Finalization	Continue working on and finalizing your project.
4:45 PM	Submission Deadline	All projects must be submitted by 4:45 PM.
5:00 PM – 5:45 PM	Project Presentations	Judges visit each team. Be ready to present and demo your project!

6:00 PM – 6:30 PM	Judging	Judges evaluate projects while participants network and relax.
6:30 PM – 7:30 PM	Closing Ceremony & Awards	Winners are announced and awards are presented.
7:30 PM – 8:00 PM	Networking	Participants can stay and network with fellow hackers, judges, and guests.

Note: Times may shift slightly — we will keep you posted throughout the day!

5. HACKATHON TRACKS & PRIZES

Participants will have the opportunity to build projects for several different hackathon tracks.

GDG Track: Build with AI for Social Good

Build an original project that uses Gemini to address a social or community problem. Teams could use Gemini to make information more accessible, build tools for communities, improve access to resources, or solve another real-world problem. These are examples within one challenge, and teams may take a different approach.

Requirements:

- Gemini must be an important part of the project.
- The project must be built around a clear social or community problem.
- The project must use at least one Google developer tool or Google Cloud service in addition to Gemini.
- Teams must use the Google Cloud credits provided for the hackathon.
- Teams must have a working project to demonstrate.

What These Terms Mean

- AI for social good: Using AI to address a problem that affects people or communities.
- Gemini: The Gemini model should be used for an important part of how the project works, rather than only being added as a basic chatbot.
- Google developer tools: Tools such as Antigravity, Gemini CLI, Google AI Studio, Vertex AI, Firebase, Cloud Run, or other Google developer technologies.

- Google Cloud credits: Credits provided to teams to use eligible Google Cloud services while building their project. For example, teams could use the credits to deploy their app on Cloud Run, use Gemini through Vertex AI, store project data with Cloud Storage or Firestore, or run other cloud services their project needs.

What a Strong Entry Looks Like

A strong project:

- Uses Gemini as an important part of how the project works
- Addresses a clear social or community problem
- Shows substantial technical work completed by the team
- Makes meaningful use of Google developer tools and the provided Cloud credits
- Has a working demonstration and a clear explanation of what the team built

Prizes

The challenge has one winning team. The winning team will receive \$500+ worth of Google equipment and products.

Terms & Conditions

All submissions must follow the hackathon's official rules and eligibility requirements. Teams must meet the GDG Track requirements above to be eligible for the prize.

SFSU Tracks: Build For SFSU

Build an original AI-powered project that addresses a real problem or opportunity at San Francisco State University.

Teams can build something that improves student life, campus operations, career development, accessibility, communication, sustainability, or another part of the SF State experience. These are examples within one challenge, and teams may take a different approach.

Requirements:

1. **The project must address a clear problem or opportunity at SFSU.**
2. **The project must clearly identify who at SFSU would benefit.** This could include students, faculty, staff, a campus office, or the broader university community.
3. **AI must be an important part of the project.** The AI should perform a meaningful function rather than being included only as a basic chatbot or add-on.
4. **Teams must have a working project to demonstrate.** A prototype, proof of concept, or deployed project is required. Slides or a proposal alone are not enough.
5. **Teams must explain how the project could realistically be used or developed further at SFSU.**

6. **Teams must consider the responsible use of AI and technology.** Projects should identify relevant privacy, security, accessibility, data, bias, or other risks and explain how they would be addressed.
7. **Each team must include at least one current SFSU student.**

Prizes: (Cash Prizes, distributed in the form of Amazon giftcards)

1st Place: \$750

2nd Place: \$500

3rd Place: \$250

Winning projects may also be considered for continued development or pilot opportunities with SFSU after the hackathon.

MLH Tracks - Best Open-Source AI Project

Build an original project that uses open-source or open-weight AI as an important part of how it works. Teams could create an agent skill, build with an open-weight large or small language model, or build or adapt an open-source model harness. These are examples within one challenge, and teams may combine them.

Requirements:

- Open-source or open-weight AI must be an important part of the project.
- The project must be published in a public GitHub repository and use an open-source license.
- An agent skill must comply with the Agent Skill Open Standard.
- A model-harness entry must include an original implementation or meaningful changes to an existing open-source harness.

What These Terms Mean

Open source: the project's source code is public and carries a license that allows others to use, modify, and share it. Common choices include [MIT](#), [Apache-2.0](#), and [GPL-3.0](#). The [OSI license list](#) includes more options.

Open-weight model: the trained model weights are available to download or run under the model provider's terms. Open-weight does not automatically mean that every part of a model is open source, so teams should name the model and link its license or terms in the README.

Small and large language models: for this challenge, a small language model has 10 billion parameters or fewer, while a large language model has more than 10 billion parameters. Google's [Gemma model overview](#) includes examples on both sides of that boundary.

Agent skill: a reusable set of instructions and supporting files that follows the [Agent Skills open standard](#).

Model harness: the software around a model that manages prompts, tools, memory, context, and actions. Teams may build one from scratch or make meaningful improvements to an existing open-source project such as OpenCode, Hermes Agent, OpenClaw, or Pi.

What a Strong Entry Looks Like

A strong project:

- Uses open-source or open-weight AI as an important part of how the project works
- Solves a clear problem or creates a useful experience
- Shows substantial technical work completed by the team
- Makes its source, license, model, and key dependencies easy to verify
- Has a working demonstration and a clear explanation of what the team built

Prizes:

The challenge has one winning team. Every member receives a DEV Badge on their DEV account. MLH may also provide MLH+DEV branded swag bags for the winning team. These may include a branded bag, notebook, and other items.

MLH Partner Challenge Track:

Google Gemma: Best Use of Gemma 4

Built with a lightweight, open model. Gemma 4 packs multimodal intelligence into an open-weights model that you can access through the Gemini API. Gemma 4 can help you:

- Work with text and images to create an assistant that understands more of what users share
- Build a focused AI tool for learning, creativity, productivity, or your community
- Experiment with an open model while using the Gemini API to move quickly from an idea to a working prototype

Participant Resources

- [Gemma 4 resources](#)
- [Gemma Quickstart](#)
- [Gemma API docs](#)
- [Gemma Beginner Guide](#)

- [Best Use of Gemma Demo](#)
- [Try it out](#)

Requirements:

- The project should use a Gemma model through the Gemini API.
- The hackers should identify the model in their project' README and show the integration in its code or demonstration.

Prizes:

The challenge has one winning team. Every member receives a MLH swag bag for the winning team. These may include a branded bag, notebook, and other items.

6. ELIGIBILITY

To be eligible for judging and prizes, participants must:

- Check in on event day.
 - Be present during the official coding period.
 - Follow the hackathon rules and Code of Conduct.
 - Submit their project before the submission deadline.
 - Participate in the judging/demo process.
-

7. TEAM FORMATION & TEAM SIZE

Teams may consist of:

- **1–4 participants**
 - You may participate individually or work with a team.
 - There will be an opportunity to find teammates during the **9:00–10:00 AM check-in period**, Participants are also welcome to form teams before the event.
-

8. WORKSHOPS

Optional workshops will be available throughout the hackathon.

Workshop #1 (student panel)

12:00 PM – 1:00 PM

Live from the Hackathon: SFSU Students on AI -Onsite at the Hackathon + Zoom

How are students actually using AI in their education, everyday lives, and as they prepare for their future careers?

Join SFSU students for a live conversation about how they use AI, where they see its value and limitations, and how they think it is changing education and the workforce. The discussion will be broadcast live from the SF Hacks x GDG AI Hackathon, with questions and participation from both the in-person and Zoom audiences.

Hackathon participants do not need to register for this event. You are welcome to attend in person, listen to the conversation, ask questions, and participate in the student panel and discussion.

The session is open to the broader SFSU community via Zoom; advance registration is required for those joining remotely.

[Register Here](#)

9. PROJECT SUBMISSION

- Projects must be submitted through **ShipYard**.
- **Submission Deadline @ 4:45 PM**
- **Late submissions will not be accepted.**
- **Submission Link: will be shared during the event**
- Before the deadline, make sure your team has completed all required submission information.
- Don't wait until the last minute to submit!

10. PROJECT DEMOS

- After the hacking period ends, teams will present their projects to the judges through live demos.
- You are strongly encouraged to demonstrate what you built.
- Judges can only evaluate what they can see and understand, so showing a working demonstration is one of the best ways to communicate what your team accomplished.
- **Your Project Doesn't Have to Be Perfect**
- Didn't finish everything you planned?

That's okay!

Hackathons move quickly, and unfinished projects are completely normal. If you completed some features, you should still present your work. Even if your project is broken or incomplete, you can explain:

1. What you tried to build
2. What you successfully completed
3. What didn't work
4. What you learned
5. What you would build next with more time

Demoing isn't only about winning. It's an opportunity to share your work and what you learned with other people.

11. HOW JUDGING WORKS

Judging takes place from approximately **5:00 PM – 6:30 PM**.

Judging Process

- Teams remain at their tables.
- Judges visit each team.
- Each team receives approximately **5 minutes** to present.
- Judges may ask questions about the project.

During Your Demo

Be prepared to:

- Show your project.
- Give a live demo when possible.
- Explain the problem you're solving.
- Explain your solution.
- Highlight what makes your project unique.
- Explain the technology you used.
- Answer 1–2 questions from the judges.

Keep your explanation focused and make sure every team member knows how the demo will work before judging begins.

12. JUDGING CRITERIA

Teams will be judged on these four criteria. Judges will weigh the criteria equally. During judging, participants should try to describe what they did for each criterion in their project.

- Idea: How well does it align with the theme and track?
- Implementation: All features presented are working. Complexity of project/features?
- Design: Is the user interface intuitive for users? How does the design lead users to different features? Is it scalable?
- Presentation: Why did you decide to make this your project/what problem are you trying to solve? Hardships and overcoming them (problem solving)? Clearly explain features.
- Track Application: How well did you utilize the technologies or problems of this track?

It's important to note that these judging criteria **DO NOT** include:

- Fully functional large-scale project. A prototype with some working features can result in a great project. It does not need to be production-ready.
- Complexity of code. Simple solutions with messy code are fine. The hackathon is meant to encourage problem-solving and innovation while fostering collaboration. Complicated code is not necessary to win.

So don't worry about coming up with the next big idea or building a company. You'll have plenty of time for that outside the hackathon. Just focus on learning, having fun, and making new friends. At the end of the day the skills you learn and the friends you make might lead to the next big thing—but you don't have to do that to win a hackathon.

13. CODE OF CONDUCT

Be respectful. Harassment and abuse are never tolerated. If you are in a situation that makes you uncomfortable at an MLH Member Event, if the event itself is creating an unsafe or inappropriate environment, or if interacting with an SF Hacks organizer or an MLH representative makes you uncomfortable, please report it using the procedures included in this document.

SF Hacks and Major League Hacking (MLH) stands for inclusivity. We believe that every single person has the right to hack in a safe and welcoming environment.

Harassment includes but is not limited to offensive verbal or written comments related to gender, age, sexual orientation, disability, physical appearance, body size, race, religion, social class, economic status, and veteran status. Additional cases of harassment include but are not limited to

sharing sexual images, deliberate intimidation, stalking, following, brigading, doxxing, harassing photography or recording, sustained disruption of talks or other events, inappropriate physical contact, and unwelcome sexual attention. If what you're doing is making someone feel uncomfortable, that counts as harassment and is enough reason to stop doing it.

A. Guidelines for Respectful Behavior and Collaboration

- Be friendly and inclusive: Treat everyone with kindness and make an effort to include others in discussions and activities.
- Communicate respectfully: Use polite language, listen actively, and be open to different perspectives.
- Encourage collaboration: Share ideas, support teammates, and contribute positively to the group's overall goals.
- Be patient: Understand that everyone has different skills and experiences, and offer help when needed.
- Foster a safe environment: Avoid offensive language or behavior, and report any incidents of harassment or discrimination.

If you are being harassed, notice that someone else is being harassed, or have any other concerns, please contact MLH using the reporting procedures defined below.

We expect participants to follow these rules at all hackathon venues, online interactions in relation to the event, hackathon-related social events, and on hackathon-supplied transportation.

B. Reporting Procedures

If you feel uncomfortable or think there may be a potential violation of the code of conduct, please report it immediately using one of the following methods. All reporters have the right to remain anonymous.

North America General Reporting: +1 409 202 6060, incidents@mlh.io

C. Consequences for violation of the code of conduct

Participants who violate the code of conduct may receive a warning or removal from the competition. In more severe cases, or if violations persist after a warning, participants may be removed from the hackathon competition to maintain a positive and respectful environment for all.

14. FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

What accommodations are available at the event?

This event offers:

- Free lunch
- Snacks
- Drinks
- Free internet access
- Power outlets

How do I connect to Wi-Fi?

Visitors

1. Open your device's Wi-Fi settings.
2. Select **SFStateGuest**.
3. Complete the required form using your full name and personal email address.
4. Sign in using the username and password sent to your email.

SF State Students

Please connect to **eduroam** or **SFState** instead of SFStateGuest when possible. This helps reduce traffic on the guest network so everyone can enjoy a faster connection.

Who should I contact if I have questions or need support?

Email the SF Hacks team at:

sfhacksteam@gmail.com

Message on Discord or reach out to an organizer!

REMEMBER!

The competition is only one part of the hackathon.

Make the most of the experience by:

- Trying something new
- Learning a new technology
- Helping another participant
- Teaching someone something you know
- Meeting new people
- Making new friends
- Building something you're excited about

You don't have to create a perfect project to have a successful hackathon.

Happy Hacking!

SF Hacks x GDG AI Hackathon